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AI



Google takes on
ChatGPT's Study Mode
with new 'Guided
Learning' tool in Gemini

As the new school year approaches, Google announced on Wednesday that it's launching a new tool called Guided Learning within Gemini. The tool serves a similar function to an AI tutor, as it's designed to help users build a deep understanding instead of just getting answers.

The launch follows just over a week after OpenAI rolled out Study Mode for ChatGPT, which is also designed to go beyond simply obtaining answers to questions by actually helping users develop critical thinking skills.

Both companies' launches come amid concerns that AI chatbots undermine the learning process because they spit out direct answers. The new tools from Google and OpenAI likely aim to address these concerns by positioning their chatbots as learning tools rather than simple answer engines.

With Guided Learning, Gemini will break down problems step-by-step and adapt explanations to its users' needs. The feature responds using images, diagrams, videos, and interactive quizzes to help users build and test themselves on their knowledge, rather than simply giving them the answer.

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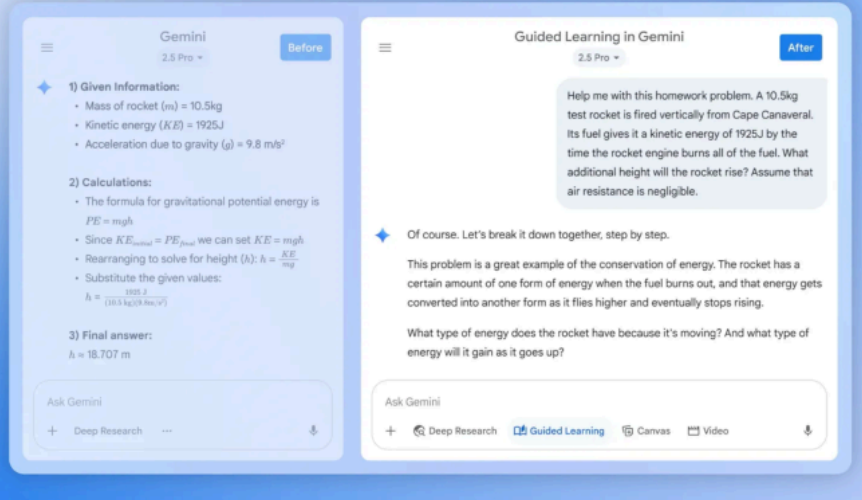


IMAGE CREDITS :GOOGLE

Google says the feature will help users uncover the “why” and “how” behind concepts.

“Whether you’re preparing for an exam about enzymes, starting the first draft of a paper on the importance of bee populations in supporting our food systems, or exploring your passion for photography, Guided Learning is a collaborative thinking partner that helps you get it — each step of the way,” wrote Maureen Heymans, Google’s VP of Learning & Sustainability, in the [blog post](#).

In addition to the new feature, Google announced that it’s working to make Gemini as a whole better equipped to help users learn. Gemini will now automatically incorporate images, diagrams, and YouTube videos directly into responses to help users better understand complex topics. Plus, users can now also ask Gemini to create flashcards and study guides based on their quiz results or other class materials.

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Google also announced on Wednesday that it's offering students in the U.S., Japan, Indonesia, Korea, and Brazil a free one-year subscription to Google's AI Pro plan.

The plan includes expanded access to [Gemini 2.5 Pro](#), [NotebookLM](#), [Veo 3](#), [Deep Research](#), and more.

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Aisha Malik

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Aisha is a consumer news reporter at TechCrunch. Prior to joining the publication in 2021, she was a telecom reporte...

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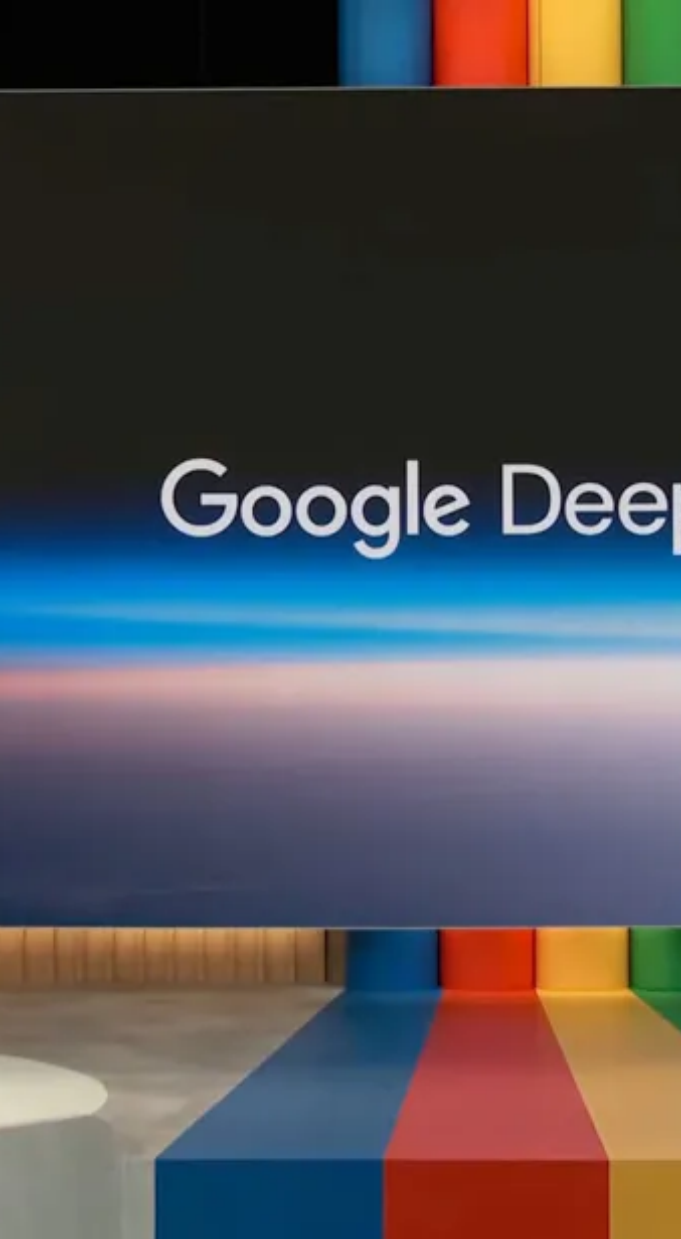


IMAGE CREDITS: GOOGLE

AI



DeepMind claims its next chatbot will rival ChatGPT

Kyle Wiggers — 12:53 PM PDT · June 26, 2023

ChatGPT might've captured the world's attention. But DeepMind, the Google-owned research lab, claims that its next large language model will rival — or even best — OpenAI's.

According to a piece in Wired, DeepMind is using techniques from AlphaGo, DeepMind's AI system that was the first to defeat a professional human player at the board game Go, to make a ChatGPT-rivalling chatbot called Gemini.

If all goes according to plan, Gemini will have the ability to plan or solve problems as well as analyze

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text, DeepMind CEO Demis Hassabis told Wired's Will Knight.

"At a high level you can think of Gemini as combining some of the strengths of AlphaGo-type systems with the amazing language capabilities of the large models," Hassabis said. "We also have some new innovations that are going to be pretty interesting."

Knight speculates that Gemini, which was briefly teased at Google's I/O developer conference in May, will leverage innovations in reinforcement learning to accomplish tasks with which today's language models struggle. Reinforcement learning involves "rewarding" an AI system for certain behaviors and/or punishing undesired ones, with the goal of "teaching" the system which behaviors to exhibit in a given situation.

As Knight notes, reinforcement learning has already led to gains in the language model space — it's key to the way systems such as [ChatGPT respond to prompts](#). DeepMind, having a wealth of experience in reinforcement learning (AlphaGo being one example), is no doubt eager to apply its learnings to the generative AI domain.

It's worth noting that Gemini isn't DeepMind's first foray into language models. Last year the company introduced Sparrow, a chatbot that the lab claimed was less likely than other language models to give "unsafe" or "inappropriate" answers to questions. Hassabis told Time in January that DeepMind would consider releasing Sparrow for a private beta sometime this year; it's unclear whether those plans are still on track.

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Gemini is, however, DeepMind's most ambitious work in the space so far, at least if early reports are to be believed. The Information [reported](#) in March that Gemini — which was spurred by the failures of Bard, Google's chatbot project — to keep [pace with ChatGPT](#), has direct participation from Google higher-ups, including Jeff Dean, the company's most senior AI research executive.

The race for dominance in the generative AI space comes amid sky-high investor — and customer — enthusiasm. [According](#) to Grand View Research, the market for generative AI — including text-analyzing AI like Gemini — could reach \$109.37 billion by 2030, an increase of 35.6% from 2020.

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Kyle Wiggers

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Kyle Wiggers was TechCrunch's AI Editor until June 2025. His writing has appeared in VentureBeat and Digital...

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Google embraces AI in the classroom with new Gemini tools for educators, chatbots for students, and more

Google on Monday [announced](#) a series of updates intended to bring its Gemini AI and other AI-powered tools deeper into the classroom. At the ISTE edtech conference, the tech giant introduced more than 30 AI tools for educators, a version of the Gemini app built for education, expanded access to its collaborative video creation app Google Vids, and other tools for managed Chromebooks.

The updates represent a major AI push in the edtech space, where educators are already struggling to adapt to how AI tools, [like AI chatbots](#) and startups that promise to help you “[cheat on everything](#),” are making their way into the learning environment.

School-aged kids and teens today are more likely to ask ChatGPT for help with their homework (or to even do it for them) than they are to ask a teacher to explain the concepts again. In higher ed, meanwhile, colleges are [wrestling with](#) whether or not plagiarism detectors can even identify AI-written content.

Amid this disruption, Google is charging ahead with AI tools, saying it thinks that “responsible AI” can help drive “more engaging and personalized learning experiences,” when used in conjunction with human-led teaching.

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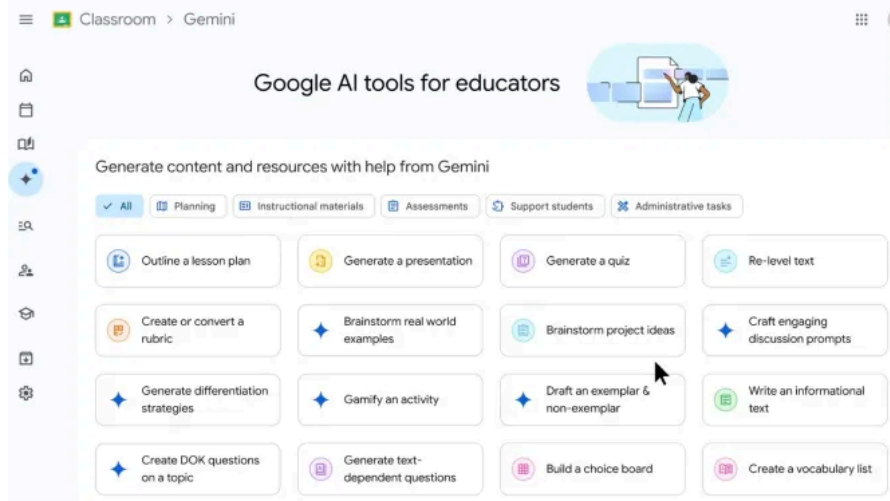


IMAGE CREDITS:GOOGLE

Since [announcing](#) its plans to bring Gemini to the classroom last year, Google on Monday said that its Gemini AI suite for educators is now available for free to all Google Workspace for Education accounts.

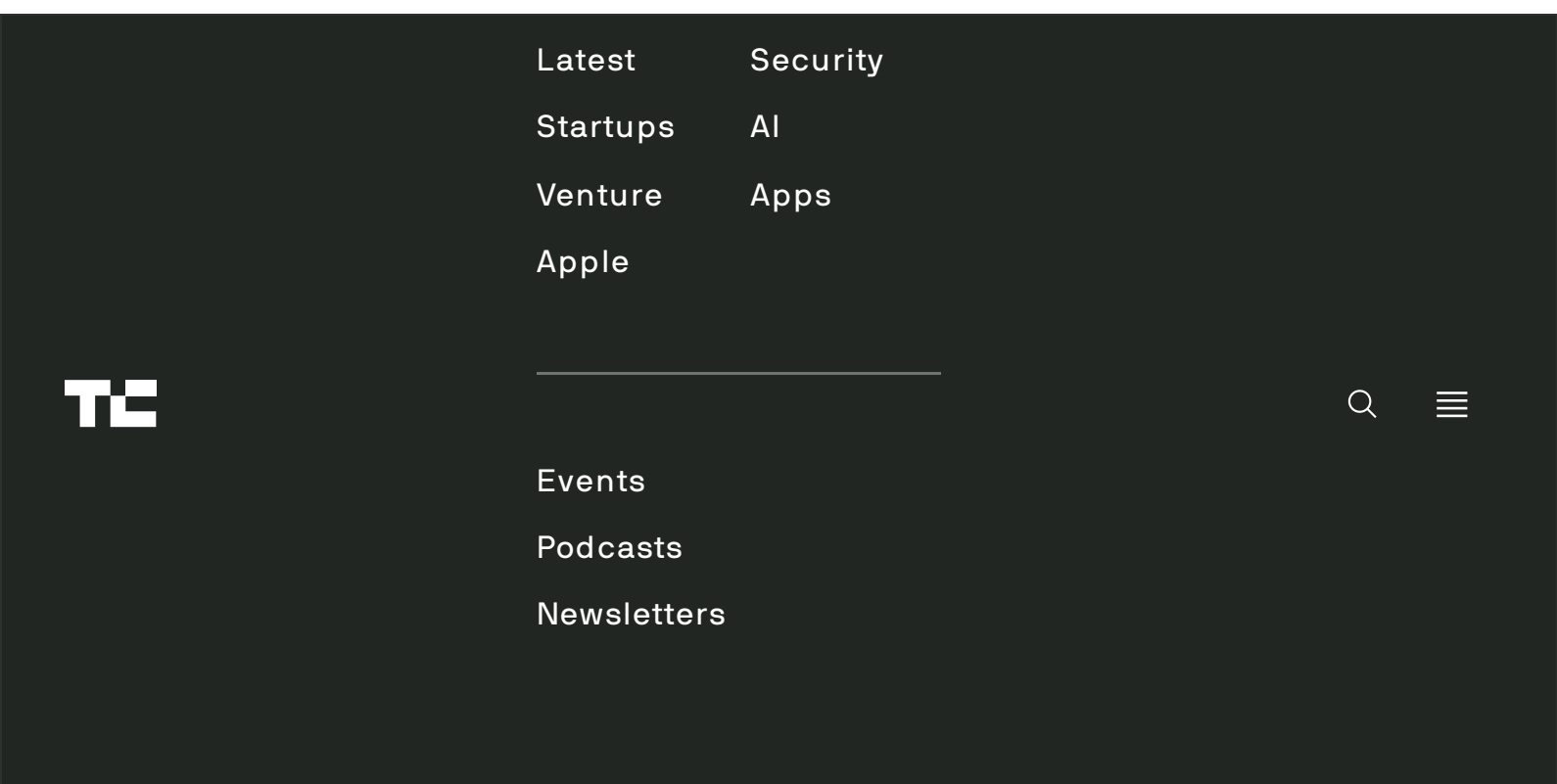


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Over the next several months, [Google will give teachers](#) the ability to create interactive study guides using the AI research tool [Notebook LM](#), along with their classroom materials.



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Teachers can also create custom versions of the Gemini AI called “[Gems](#),” which will work as [AI experts](#) that help students who need extra support or want to better understand the subject.

This is essentially just taking an activity that students are already doing — asking an AI chatbot to explain a topic or answer questions — and redirecting that activity back to Google's own AI technology, where it's specifically been trained on the teacher's own classroom materials.

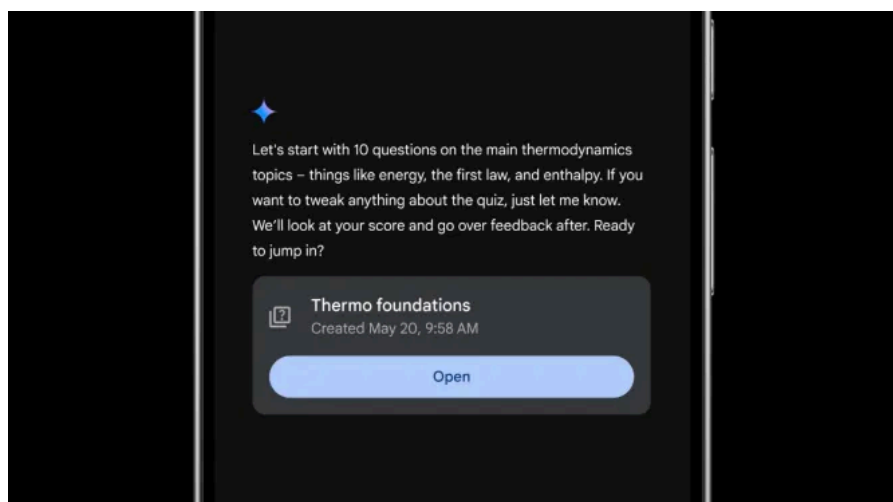


IMAGE CREDITS:GOOGLE

Soon, teachers will also be able to offer students real-time support for the AI-powered reading buddy

when using the [Read Along in Classroom](#) tool.

Google is expanding basic access to its AI-powered video creator, [Google Vids](#), as well, to make it available to all Google Workspace for Education users. Teachers can use the tool to make instructional videos, while students can use Vids for things like book reports or other assignments.

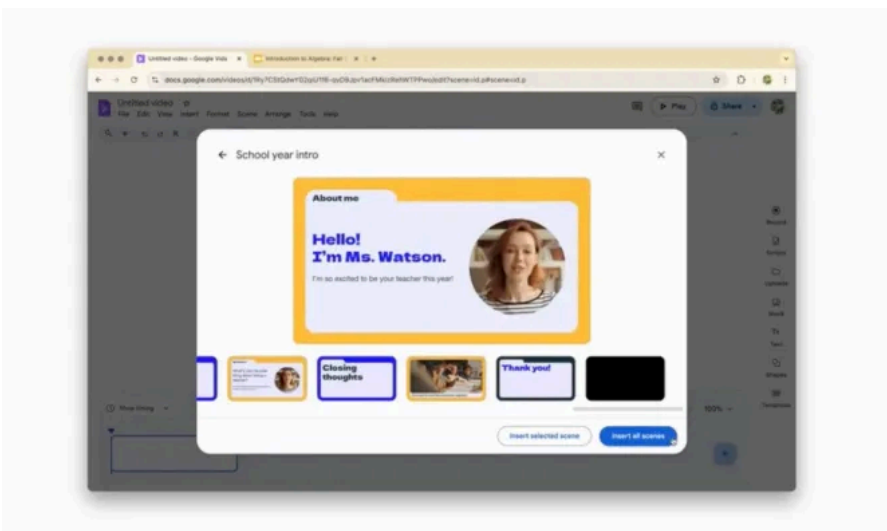


IMAGE CREDITS:GOOGLE

The company is also [rolling](#) out a series of new features designed to track student progress against learning standards and skills, view analytics on student performance and engagement, better secure Gemini user data and data in Gmail, manage who has access to AI tools like Gemini and Notebook LM, have better control over Google Meet waiting rooms, and more.

Plus, along with a handful of updates for managed Chromebooks, Google introduced a new teaching mode [called Class tools](#). This allows teachers to connect directly with their students via Google Classroom and share content to the kids' screens, like videos, articles, slides, and quizzes. These tools can be adapted to the student's own language, if need be, and are designed to keep kids focused on learning by restricting browsing to specific tabs.



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Sarah Perez
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Sarah has worked as a reporter for TechCrunch since August 2011. She joined the company after having...

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Gemini Live first look: Better than talking to Siri, but worse than I'd like

Maxwell Zeff — 2:38 PM PDT · August 13, 2024



Google launched [Gemini Live](#) during its [Made by Google](#) event Tuesday. The feature allows you to have a semi-natural spoken conversation, not typed out, with an AI chatbot powered by Google's latest large language model. TechCrunch was there to test it out firsthand.

Gemini Live is Google's answer to [OpenAI's Advanced Voice Mode](#). ChatGPT's nearly identical feature that's currently in a limited alpha test. While OpenAI beat Google to the punch by demoing the feature first, Google is the first to roll out the finalized feature.

In my experience, these low latency, verbal features feel much more natural than texting with ChatGPT, or even talking with Siri or Alexa. I found that Gemini Live responded to questions in less than two seconds, and was able to pivot fairly quickly when interrupted. Gemini Live is not perfect, but it's the best way to use your phone hands-free that I've seen yet.

How Gemini Live works

Before speaking with Gemini Live, the feature lets you choose from 10 voices, compared to just three

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voices from OpenAI. Google worked with voice actors to create each one. I appreciated the variety there, and found each one to sound very humanlike.

In one example, a Google product manager verbally asked Gemini Live to find family-friendly wineries near Mountain View with outdoor areas and playgrounds nearby, so that kids could potentially come along. That's a far more complicated task than I'd ask Siri — or Google Search, frankly — but Gemini successfully recommended a spot that met the criteria: Cooper-Garrod Vineyards in Saratoga.

That said, Gemini Live leaves something to be desired. It seemed to hallucinate a nearby playground called Henry Elementary School Playground that is supposedly “10 minutes away” from that vineyard. There are other playgrounds nearby in Saratoga, but the nearest Henry Elementary School is more than a two-hour drive from there. There's a Henry Ford Elementary School in Redwood City, but it's 30 minutes away.

Google liked to show off how users can interrupt Gemini Live mid-sentence, and the AI will quickly pivot. The company says this allows users to control the conversation. In practice, this feature doesn't work perfectly. Sometimes Google's project managers and Gemini Live were talking over each other, and the AI didn't seem to pick up on what was said.

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Notably, Google is not allowing Gemini Live to sing or mimic any voices outside of the 10 it provides, according to product manager Leland Rechis. The company is likely doing this to avoid run-ins with copyright law. Further, Rechis said Google is not focused on getting Gemini Live to understand emotional intonation in a user's voice — something OpenAI touted during its demo.

Overall, the feature seems like a great way to dive deeply into a subject more naturally than you would with simple Google Search. Google notes that Gemini Live is a step along the way to [Project Astra](#), the fully multimodal AI model the company debuted during Google I/O. For now, Gemini Live is just capable of voice conversations; however, in the future Google wants to add real-time video understanding.

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Maxwell Zeff

Senior AI Reporter | [X](#)

Maxwell Zeff is a senior reporter at TechCrunch specializing in AI. Previously with Gizmodo, Bloomberg,...

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